

Marrella

Some 500 million years ago, the tiny, shrimplike creature *Marrella* darted around the seafloor, beating its 50 feathery legs as it swam in search of dead animals to eat. *Marrella* appeared in the “Cambrian Explosion,” when a vast range of animal life evolved in a short space of time.

Marrella

ma-RELL-a



- **When** 515–500 million years ago (Middle Cambrian)
- **Fossil location** Canada
- **Habitat** Seabed
- **Length** $\frac{3}{4}$ in (2 cm)

Marrella's head was protected by a large and possibly colorful shield with four long, backward-pointing spikes. Under the shield was *Marrella*'s flexible body, which consisted of 25 segments, each with a pair of feathery legs that doubled as gills for breathing underwater. Attached to the head were two pairs of long, flexible antennae (feelers). *Marrella* was one of the first arthropods—the group that today includes insects, spiders, and other animals with external skeletons.

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Marrella probably swam along the seabed or just above it, using its long antennae to sweep the mud in search of food.

Shield

Antennae
(feelers)

